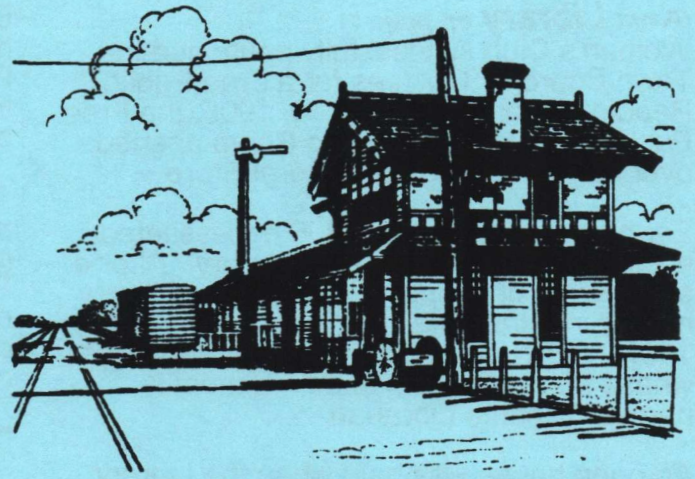
Mountain View Historical Association Newsletter

P.O. Box 252
Mountain View, CA 94042

Hilton U. Brown, III - Editor



Southern Pacific Depot — Mountain View, California, built in 1888

Fighting Fire & Disaster
The May Meeting

The history of fires and disasters in Mountain View and the men and women who have dealt with them will be the themes of the May 4, 1997, meeting of the Mountain View Historical Association.

Battalion Chief John Fetz of the Mountain View Fire Department will be our speaker. The Fire Department, initially a volunteer organization, and now a thoroughly professional and modern emergency services team, has been an important part of Mountain View since the City's earliest days. By coincidence, the *Old Newspaper Items* column in this Newsletter from 100 years ago describes the construction of a building which was to include the Fire Department. From about the same period, the obituary for Pauline Bellew mentions the wedding celebration which the Department provided for one of its own. Chief Fetz will talk about some of those early days of the Department, some of the disasters they had to deal with, the growing pains, and something about the range of services the Department now provides.

The Historical Association meeting should be of particular interest since many members of the Mountain View Historical Association participated in one way or another with the Department in its earlier days.

History of the Mountain View Public Library
The February Meeting

Susan Ozubko, Director of Library Services for the City of Mountain View, was our speaker at the February 2, 1997 meeting of the Mountain View Historical Association. Her presentation covered the history of the library in Mountain View from the early pioneer days up to the present. The presentation included many illustrations.

The first Library and Reading Room in Mountain View was opened to the public December 1, 1890. By 1892 the collection included about 700 books. Judge B. E. Burns acted as Librarian and continued to sponsor the Library for many years. In 1903 the Library moved from the basement of the J. S. Mockbee residence at Hope and Villa Streets to the Library of the new high school in Old Mountain View.

In 1903 Mr. B. C. Nichols, owner of the *Mountain View Register* opened a Circulating Library. A membership subscription was $3.00 per year. In 1908 William Garliepp opened the Tarbad Inn Circulating Library. There is no record as to the duration of either of these ventures.

On March 10, 1905, the Mountain View

*(See **Library** on page 2)*

*(From **Library** on page 1)*
Woman's Club successfully petitioned the Town Board of Trustees for a Free Public Reading Room. On April 14, 1905, the Free Public Library and Reading Room opened over Rogers & Rogers General Store.

Earthquake damage in 1906 necessitated finding new quarters for the Library. After a succession of temporary rooms, the Library moved into the Swall Building in September 1907. Miss Laurabelle (Dolly) Graham, for whose father Graham Middle School is named, became Librarian.

An open house was held when the Library was established on the first floor of the then-new City Hall, April 9, 1910. There were 300 books on the shelves and there were one thousand cardholders.

Mr. A. L. Palmer assumed the office of Librarian in 1919. In 1929 the Library was moved to the second floor of City Hall. Mr. Palmer retired in 1944, but lived to a grand old age of 105. Mrs. Edna Roth succeeded Mr. Palmer and served until retirement in 1957.

In 1952 the Library moved to a converted store at 939 Dana Street. The collection numbered 17,000 volumes.

In 1956 a $160,000 bond was passed for the first Library building, an 8,400 square foot structure with a capacity of 65,000 volumes. Mrs. Edith Duke was appointed Librarian and assumed the responsibility of completing the building on Franklin Street. In 1968 a three-story, 22,800 square foot addition was added, bringing the capacity up to 160,000 volumes.

Ruth Lawson was appointed City Librarian in 1973, and served until her retirement in 1981. She was succeeded by Ruth Stilwell, who served until 1988, when Susan Ozubko was appointed as Library Services Director.

After many efforts, in 1993 a $14 million bond issue to fund construction of a new library was placed on the ballot, but the measure failed by a very narrow margin. Alternate funding was found and in 1996 work commenced on the new Mountain View Public Library. The library is presently located in temporary trailers at the corner of Moffett Boulevard and Middlefield Road.

Excavation for the new Library forced the relocation of about 34 graves from the old Presbyterian Church Cemetery. It proved impossible to precisely identify these remains, but they have been respectfully re-interred.

The new Library will blend with the architecture of the Civic Center, and yet be a good neighbor to the residents of Franklin Street. The new Library will be equipped to deal with the age of technology with fiber optics, cabling and computers. The expected opening date is December 1997.

MOUNTAIN VIEW'S 'RED SHADOW'

by Carol Fischer

What do the famous lyricist, Oscar Hammerstein and the City of Mountain View have in common? Would you believe the dashing "Red Shadow" in the operetta, *The Desert Song*, was Perry Askam, the grandson of Henry Rengstorff?

Perry Askam, the Broadway matinee idol of the 1920's, was the son of Helena Rengstorff (one of Henry's seven children) and Dr. Oliver Perry Askam. Both Perry and his older brother, Earl, were orphaned as children. Perry was then raised by his mother's sister, Mrs. Elise Rengstorff Haag. As Mrs. Haag had no children, Perry inherited the family home, Rengstorff House, at the time of her death in 1952.

Before becoming a Broadway star, Perry ventured to Alaska in 1915 in pursuit of gold. Not finding his fortune, he went to Europe and volunteered with the French army during World War I. While driving a Red Cross ambulance in Italy, Perry was hospitalized for malaria. In the bed next to him was another young ambulance driver recuperating from shrapnel wounds--Ernest Hemingway. The two young soldiers became friends and enjoyed each other's company as they toured the small eateries of Milan. Immortalizing his experiences, Hemingway later wrote a novel entitled "A Farewell to Arms" depicting wartime Italy with an ambulance driver as the story's hero.

*(See **Red Shadow** on page 3)*

*(From **Red Shadow** on page 2)*
Perry Askam's baritone kept him employed beyond the lights of Broadway. After touring the United States for five years with *The Desert Song*, he sang solos for both the San Francisco Symphony and the Los Angeles Philharmonic. In one 1956 interview, Mr. Askam admits to leads in a "couple of small movies" with Warner Brothers in the 1930's (*Palo Alto Times,* September 27, 1956). Earl Askam, Perry's older brother, actually had signed a contract with Cecil B. DeMille but died in 1940 before reaching stardom.

Even though Perry Askam was friends with the likes of Al Jolson, Ernest Hemingway and Ezio Pinza, it was to his childhood home in Mountain View that Perry and his wife, Frances, retired. Perry spent his last years at his 165-acre ranch at 1737 Stierlin Road "singing to the cows." Perry found great contentment wearing "jeans and an old shirt instead of grease paint and an operatic wig." (*Mountain View Register,* May 3, 1953). Perry died at the age of 60 in 1961.



In Commemoration

Pauline Ivancovich Bellew: 91, in Sunnyvale, February 24, 1997. Born in Watsonville, she was a member of the first graduating class from the new Mountain View High School on Castro Street in 1924. Her parents immigrated from Croatia. She married Kyrle Bellew, at the time a volunteer with the Mountain View Fire Department, and the firemen drove them up and down Main Street in celebration. She leaves a brother-in-law James Bellew of Fremont, and numerous nieces and nephews. She was for many years a member of the Mountain View Historical Association.

Albert S. Miller: 76, in Yountville, March 13, 1997. Lived at the Veteran's Home in Yountville. He leaves a brother and sister, both out of state, and a niece, Lynn Cohen of San Francisco. He was a member of American Legion Post #248 and the Mountain View Historical Association.

Chief Robert K. Schatz: 69, at El Camino Hospital in Mountain View, March 29, 1997, of emphysema. Born in Pocatello, Idaho, he grew up in Oakland. He served in both the Army and the Navy. He earned a degree in criminology from San Jose State University and was also a graduate of the FBI National Academy. Bob Schatz served 34 years with the Mountain View Police Department, the last thirteen as Chief.

Chief Schatz served for nearly nine years on the Mountain View City Council, and served as Mayor for two terms. Bob Schatz was a man of warmth and good humor, and always caring for his fellow humans. Chief Schatz was a member of many civic organizations, and a very active and supportive member of the Mountain View Historical Association.

SAVE THE ADOBE TASKFORCE

MISSION STATEMENT: *The mission of the "Save the Adobe Task Force" is to restore and preserve Mountain View's historic Adobe Building for use as a vital community resource.*

The task force has continued to meet regularly and has formulated some important positions. The future use of the Adobe Building should be as a cultural center based upon its design, site, historical value and architecture. Restoration keeping the integrity of the original structure would provide for a variety of cultural uses such as a museum, a place for special exhibits, handicraft shows and meetings of other interest groups. It could serve as a place for dinners, wedding receptions, dances and similar events.

Renovation and site development would greatly enhance this gateway to the historic downtown area.

We have reviewed the preliminary engineering and architectural studies and we are convinced that a safe, attractive and historically valuable addition to downtown Mountain View is viable.

We need the support of every interested Mountain View resident. We must raise substantial amounts in cash and pledges to preserve the Adobe and make it into the Mountain View asset that it should be. If you can help, or if you have ideas that may help, contact the Task Force at;

Save the Adobe Task Force
P.O. Box 252
Mountain View, CA 94042

OLD NEWSPAPER ITEMS
Noted by Barbara Kinchen

100 YEARS AGO (1896): The citizens of Mountain View have purchased a lot on Hope Street and they will shortly commence to erect a two-story building, the lower floor of which will be used for a fire department and the upper floor for a court house. In the rear of this they intend to erect a branch jail. "This is something that Mountain View has long needed."

An elderly gentleman died as a result of injuries received while riding a bicycle. He was 81 years old.

A school census shows that within Whisman School District there are 20 children between five and 17 years of age and 16 less than five years. Mountain View School District has 381 of school age and 123 under age five.

75 YEARS AGO (1922): "Only mothers of commonplace children ever expect to grow orchids from turnip seed."

Hartley Hardware had the new Columbia Grafonolas (phonograph record players) with streamline cabinets to harmonize with living room furniture. Prices ranged from $30 to $150.

Memorial Day exercises were held at the old Mountain View Cemetery on Castro Street, followed by a luncheon by the newly organized American Legion Auxiliary honoring three members of the local G.A.R. (Grand Army of the Republic).

Northern California Packing Company is now operating the former McCarthy Cannery at Bailey Avenue and the railroad tracks.

The Businessmen's Commercial Club is reorganizing as the Mountain View Chamber of Commerce.

A very sound sleeper awoke and went to get his morning's bottle of milk and found the front porch of his new cottage badly damaged. Two windows were blown out and the door was splintered. Neighbors had heard an explosion about midnight but did not report it thinking it had something to do with the fire alarm sounded a short time before. There was no clue as to who had caused this crime or why. *(See **Old Newspapers** on page 5)*

*(From **Old Newspapers** on page 4)*
The Mountain View Choral Society, Neil Darrah directing, gave its first concert and was well received.

Local berry growers are shipping out two train loads of fruit each day from the new $50,000 Ice and Pre-cooling Plant at Mariposa Avenue and the Southern Pacific tracks.

50 YEARS AGO (1947): "John Law Closes in Quickly." Five Mountain View High School students have already begun serving 30-day terms at the Santa Clara County Farm for their part in car lootings and robberies at the Adobe, Woman's Club, Sterling Lumber and Escano's Grocery, all of which occurred within the past few weeks.

Taking advantage of a telephone strike, Sheriff's Deputies confiscated slot machines at a number of establishments, including the Old Corral on Bayshore Highway. Proprietors were unable to phone ahead and warn others that a raid was underway.

Sugar rationing ended.

A new contract for Santa Clara County carpenters sets the hourly rate at $2.00, a raise of 25¢ an hour.

The Methodist Church Memorial Chimes were heard for the first time. Mr. and Mrs. Charles Lawson presented their church with the special chimes, a memorial to the Mountain View men who lost their lives in World War II.

Tony Janovich pitched a no-hit, no-run game against Salinas Legion Post. Final score was Mountain View American Legion 14, Salinas 0.

Two beautiful new Packards were added to the Mountain View Yellow Cab fleet and more are on the way. Owners are Mr. and Mrs. George Schoux and her son, D.O. Myers, and they employ eight drivers.

A special census shows that Mountain View's population has risen from 3,946 in 1940 to 5,868, mostly due to annexations. The city will receive a larger amount from the State Gas Tax Fund, which is based on population.

25 YEARS AGO (1972): Judith Moss becomes the first woman to serve on City Council. She was top vote getter in this election - her fourth try.

Opened for sale at Tyrella and Evandale Avenue are 65 townhouses which were built at a factory in Gilroy, trucked to the site in units and then lifted into place by cranes. The three bedroom homes sell for $26,500. Dukor Modular Systems, Inc. claims these are the first modular homes offered to the general public, all others having been rentals or retirement projects.

Antiwar activists firebombed the Army Recruiting Office at 655 Evelyn Avenue causing $30,000 in damages. Temporary quarters operated first out of a mobile van then from 257 Castro Street, where the office was trashed by 50 protestors demanding that military recruitment must not be done in Mountain View.

NEW TO THE PIONEER ROOM

Reported by Barbara Kinchen

FROM MARY A. BULF: Two beautiful postcards of the Old Mill interior.

FROM THE ESTATE OF ANNA BRISKI: *History of Santa Clara County, California* by Eugene T. Sawyer, published 1922, 1692 pages. Included are biographies, some with pictures, of many prominent citizens. Mrs. Briski was given this book by the Ehrhorn family in 1958 and it has been presented to the Historical Association by Mrs. Margaret Moore, Mrs. Briski's sister.

FROM LENNART AHLKVIST: 1) eight x 10 copy of a photo taken by Lennart of the 1888 train station. Taken from the tracks it clearly shows the ticket office and waiting room side of the old building. 2) a 1984-snapshot print envelope from Ray's Camera Shop, 293 Castro Street, Mtn. View. 3) Tape recorder record of a 1973 Historical Association program with Dr. Bruntz of San Jose State University as speaker.

FROM VIRGINIA MIRAMONTES VAN HOOK: 14 snapshots from the Miramontes family album, including the Pacific

*(See **Pioneer Room** on page 6)*

*(From **Pioneer Room** on page 5)*
Press swimming pool, Press employees, Miramontes home at 251 Palo Alto Avenue, the Academy (or Pacific Press) Band marching on Villa Street, and a seven x 10 photo of the Pacific Press Orchestra on the Assembly Hall stage. Across the back of the stage is a painting done by Lennart Ahlkvist's father.

FROM PAULINE GIBSON BENNETT: Autographed copy of a 1965 book by Robert K. Buell, *Wild White Wings.*

HELP! Chuck Thompson will be away on May 4th so Helen Newfarmer and I would appreciate any help in placing chairs (100) and tables (five) for the meeting. Please come at 1:30 P.M.

Thank you! Edna Thompson — **HELP!**

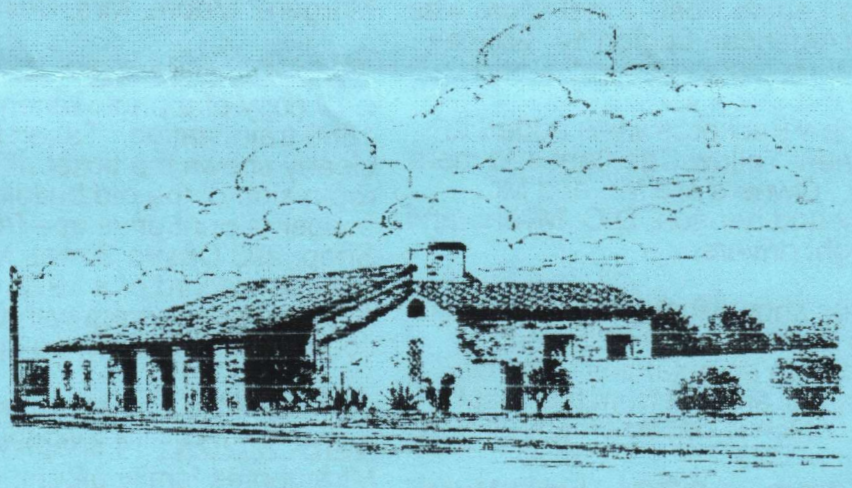
CONGRATULATIONS!

Congratulations to Special Member ***Lena Alameda***, celebrating her 99th Birthday!

Membership Rosters will be mailed with this Newsletter to all members in good standing. Any questions please call Edna Thompson at (415) 967 3116. Thank you.

WHAT'S NEW IN NEWSLETTERS?

If you are even a casual reader of this Newsletter it will be obvious that something has changed! The editor has acquired a new computer and new software, so it seemed appropriate to try out a new layout, some illustrations, and a different font. Please, let me know if you have strong feelings about any of this. My objective is serve you, the membership of the Mountain View Historical Association.



Membership Report

Reported by Edna Thompson

A list of members of the Mountain View Historical Association is available to members from the Chair of the Membership Committee. Dues are $ 7.00 per year for an individual or $10.00 per year for a family, and Life Membership is $100.00 per person.

Life Members	46
Special Members	2
Honored Member	1
Individual Members	144
Family Memberships	57
Total Members	250

New Members (Since last Newsletter)

Life Members:

Alfred P. Chasuk
Alice D. Holden
Nancy L. Smith
Richard M. Smith
H. Lee Stillens

Individual Members

Mary M. Cartozian

Family Membership

Joseph and Margaret Cusimano

Association Officers and Board Members

President	Ralph Faravelli
Past President & Social	Wally Erichsen
Vice President	Arthur Walton
Secretary	Eva Mockbee
Treasurer	June de Larios
Membership	Edna Thompson
Newsletter & Program	Hilton Brown
Hospitality	Mary Esther Walton
Memorial/Remembrance	Margaret Peterson
Ways & Means	Joseph Sweeney
Historical Data	Barbara Kinchen
Amplification/Recording	Albert Jehning

Regular meetings of the Mountain View Historical Association are held on the first Sunday of February, May, August and November. The Newsletter is mailed approximately two weeks before each meeting. Deadline for copy for the Newsletter is the third Sunday before each meeting. Short items on appropriate topics submitted by any member of the Association will be considered for publication.

Life Members

Mario Ambra	Lorena Anderson
Dena K. Bonnell	Reynolds Camp
Cliff Del Carlo	Alfred P. Chasuk
Ruth Erichsen	Wallace Erichsen
Carmen Farvelli	Ralph Faravelli
Roger Fellows	Patricia Figueroa
Marion Grimm	Estelle Stagg Heffelfinger
Bill Henderson	Eleanor McGlynn Henderson
Charles Hirschbek	DeWitt Hogle
Norene Hogle	Alice D. Holden
George Holden	George Jagels
Al Jehning	Robert W. Kirby
Joe Kleitman	Helen Shearer Krogh
Holly Urban Moore Leonard	Kenneth Richard Malovos
Madeline Chargon Malovos	Eva Mockbee
Gail Urban Moore	Mimi Mourkas
Patricia J. Reyburn	Elaine Marcetti Shearer
Nancy L. Smith	Richard M. Smith
Martin J. Spangler	Honor Spitz
H. Lee Stillens	Linda Swan
Joseph Sweeney	Roberta Sweeney
Edna Thompson	Sally Moore Taboada
John Viscovich	Bill Wissell

Treasurer's Report

Treasurer A. J. de Larios

January 1, 1997 - March 31, 1997

Balance 1/1/97		8,394.89
Income:		
Membership	1,315.00	
Sales	24.00	
M.V. Reimbursement	500.00	
Adobe Fund	25.00	
Interest	23.12	
Total Income		1,887.12
Expenses;		
Administration	268.06	
Save the Adobe	0.00	
Newsletter	111.63	
Total Expense		379.69
Balance 3/31/97		9,902.32
Fund Balances:		
Adobe Fund	2,529.56	
Memorial Fund	75.00	
Life Member Fund	4,600.00	
General Fund	2,697.76	

$5000 Cash invested in 6.02%, 9 month CD on 3/26/97

MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

REGULAR MEETING

Sunday, May 4, 1997
2:00 PM
Senior Center - 266 Escuela

Topic and Speaker

Fighting Fire & Disaster

Presented by
Battalion Chief John Fetz
Mountain View Fire Department

MEMBERSHIP: Any person who signifies interest in the aims of this Association and who pays the specified annual dues may become a member of the Association.

AIMS: The aims of this Association are: to gather and preserve historical data relative to the early settlement and development of the area in and around the present City of Mountain View; to collect, record, edit and publish a history of the pioneering activities of this area; to preserve historic objects and places; to cooperate with other organizations in the Santa Clara Valley on projects deemed worthy by our membership.

MEMBERSHIP APPLICATION

NAME: _____

ADDRESS: _____

_____

_____

TELEPHONE: _____

NEW___RENEWAL___Regular Member $ 7.00/yr
Family Membership $10.00/yr, Life Member $100.00.
Make Check Payable to:
Mountain View Historical Association
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042

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MOUNTAIN VIEW, CA 94042

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